

Fourth Sunday After Pentecost

Dominica Quarta Post Pentecosten

TLM propers: Christ's word orders a groaning world and a rebellious will

Proper	TLM text / reference	Scriptural axis	Connection
Introit	<i>Dominus illuminatio mea</i> (Ps. 26:1–3)	Light, salvation, courage	God's light does not deny conflict; it gives the endangered worshipper courage to enter it faithfully.
Collect	<i>Da nobis, quaesumus, Domine</i>	Providence, peace, devotion	The Church asks that the world's course be peacefully ordered and her own devotion made tranquil.
Epistle	Rom. 8:18–23	Creation's groaning and bodily glory	Present suffering belongs to a creation awaiting incorruption and the redemption of the body.
Gradual	<i>Propitius esto, Domine, peccatis nostris</i> (Ps. 78:9–10)	Forgiveness and deliverance	Before apostolic fruit, the Church confesses need and refuses to make results her own vindication.
Alleluia	<i>Deus, qui sedes super thronum</i> (Ps. 9:5, 10)	Judgment and refuge	The Judge enthroned above the sea interprets depth and failure under divine justice and refuge.
Gospel	Luke 5:1–11	Christ's word, the catch, vocation	Teaching precedes mission; abundance follows Christ's command and brings Peter to confession and vocation.
Offertory	<i>Illumina oculos meos</i> (Ps. 12:4–5)	Illumination against death	The offering asks for eyes kept awake when exhaustion and apparent futility invite surrender.
Secret	<i>Oblationibus nostris ... placare susceptis ... ad te nostras etiam rebelles compelle propitius voluntates</i>	Offerings received; wills drawn	God is asked to accept the oblations and mercifully draw even resistant wills toward himself, the interior counterpart to Christ's command at the lake.
Communion	<i>Dominus firmamentum meum</i> (Ps. 17:3)	Refuge and deliverance	The one sent into the deep receives God himself as strength, refuge, and deliverer.
Postcommunion	<i>Mysteria nos, Domine, sumpta purificant</i>	Purification and protection	Mission ends neither in technique nor visible success: the mysteries purify and guard the laborer.
Sense	Synthesis		
Literal	Luke narrates Jesus teaching from Simon's boat, commanding a new cast after an empty night, granting a catch that strains nets and boats, and calling Peter to catch men; Romans describes creation and believers groaning for bodily redemption.		
Allegorical	Augustine reads the first catch as the Church in her present, mixed condition. The boat bears Christ's teaching, and the net gathers people through the apostolic mission his word initiates.		
Moral	The disciple submits discouragement and even a rebellious will to Christ's efficacious word, obeys after failure, confesses sin when grace bears fruit, and follows rather than claiming the catch.		
Anagogical	Chrysostom reads creation's groaning as desire for incorruption and the body's perfect glory; Augustine contrasts the present mixed catch with the final shore and resurrection.		

Creation, Church, and Will Under the Word

Governing question

The formulary moves across three scales without changing its center. Creation groans for incorruption; the Church labors through an empty night and a burdened catch; the individual brings darkened sight and a rebellious will. At every scale, order is received from God's providence and Christ's efficacious word rather than manufactured from below.

Scale	Disorder experienced	Divine action	Promised form
Creation and body	Present suffering, vanity, corruption, travail, and the body still awaiting redemption	The Collect places the world's course under God's order; Romans names the Spirit's firstfruits and coming glory.	Creation's freedom from corruption and the embodied glory of God's children.
Church and mission	An empty night, straining nets, overloaded boats, and a catch not yet at the final shore	Christ teaches, commands the cast, supplies the catch, receives confession, and gives vocation.	A gathered people whose present mixture and burden await resurrection's completion.
Person and will	Fear, sin, exhausted perception, divided desire, and resistance	God is light; the Offertory asks illuminated eyes; the Secret asks that even rebellious wills be mercifully compelled toward him.	Obedience, purification, protection, and God himself as strength and refuge.

Editorial liturgical synthesis. Romans directly supplies the cosmic and bodily horizon; Luke supplies the boat, word, catch, confession, and call; the Secret supplies the resistant will. Their presentation as three nested scales is this guide's map of the appointed formulary, not a patristic account of its composition.

The center is not visible success

Christ's word does produce a catch, but the catch leads Peter to confession and discipleship, not self-certification. The Sunday ends with purification and protection, because mission remains an effect of grace before, during, and after abundance.

Romans 8: Travail Ordered to Glory

Paul does not minimize present suffering. He changes its horizon. Creation waits, believers groan within themselves, the Spirit is possessed as firstfruits, and adoption is awaited as the redemption of the body. The tension is neither simple absence nor completed possession.

Pauline phrase	St. John Chrysostom, <i>Romans 14</i>	Doctrinal force	Boundary
The expectation of creation	Paul personifies creation so that its longing for the glory of God's children becomes audible.	Non-rational creation is bound to humanity's history and will share the honor of the restored children.	Personification should not be flattened into a claim that every creature waits with a human psychology.
Subjected to vanity, not willingly	Chrysostom stresses that creation did not incur corruption for its own fault; it followed humanity's subjection and was subjected in hope.	Creation's bondage is penal yet hope-filled, not evidence that matter is evil by nature.	The passage does not absolve human sin by blaming the world.

Pauline phrase	St. John Chrysostom, <i>Romans 14</i>	Doctrinal force	Boundary
Groaning and travailing	Travail points toward birth and newness rather than an endless cycle of pain.	Christian lament can be truthful because its promised end is incorruption, not because suffering is unreal.	Travail is not itself redemption; hope is fixed on God's act.
Firstfruits of the Spirit	Believers already possess the pledge while still groaning for completion.	Adoption is real now and still awaits manifestation in the redeemed body.	Already and not-yet must remain joined; neither presumption nor despair fits the text.
Redemption of our body	Chrysostom calls the promised redemption complete and irreversible.	Salvation concerns the body itself, freed from corruption, not an escape of the true person from embodiment.	Cosmic renewal and bodily resurrection are related but not identical subjects.

St. Irenaeus — the same mortal body vivified

Against Heresies V.7.1–2 appeals to Romans 8:11 to identify what God will vivify: the mortal body that dies and is laid in the earth. A spiritual body is not a discarded body but this body raised through the Spirit for perpetual life. Irenaeus comments on the same Pauline context and blocks an anti-material reading of the Epistle.

Three distinctions in Christian hope

- Creation's liberation is not creation's divinization: it shares the freedom proper to the manifested children without ceasing to be creature.
- Present firstfruits are not final possession: the Spirit makes groaning hopeful, not obsolete.
- Bodily redemption is not mere resuscitation into the old conditions: incorruption and glory name a condition no longer returning to bondage.

From the Epistle to the Lake

The Epistle and Gospel do not share one image, but they share a grammar: creation is subject to corruption yet held in hope; fishermen are subject to exhaustion yet addressed by a word; the Church's will is resistant yet placed under mercy. In each case the creature is not erased but brought into a divinely given future.

Moment	What is genuinely creaturely	What remains God's work
Creation groans and waits	Creaturely history, pain, and expectation are real.	Liberation into glory is promised and accomplished by God.
Simon reports an empty night	Skill, labor, disappointment, and the truthful report of failure remain real.	The command and the catch come from Christ; result cannot be reverse-engineered from technique.
The partners answer the signal	Cooperation, shared burden, and ecclesial office are real.	Christ continues to fill the apostolic net and define its end.
Peter confesses and follows	Recognition, fear, surrender, and discipleship are personal acts.	Christ first discloses holiness, says fear not, and turns the fisherman into an apostle.
The Church offers and prays	Oblations and wills are truly ours.	Acceptance, interior conversion, purification, and protection are requested from God.

Christ's Word and the Apostolic Catch

Luke orders the narrative carefully: the multitude presses to hear the word of God; Christ teaches from Simon's boat; only then does he command the cast. Doctrine precedes abundance, and the miracle confirms the authority of the teacher who gives the mission.

Witness	Direct emphasis	Contribution to the catch	Boundary to retain
St. Cyril of Alexandria	<i>Commentary on Luke</i> , at 5:2–8	The fishermen who will catch the world are first caught in Christ's own net. Teaching is joined to a sign that pledges his almighty will; creation ministers to his command.	The miracle confirms Christ, not a general promise that every faithful project will have measurable success.
St. Cyril of Alexandria	Same direct locus	The visible catch typifies apostolic preaching and the gathering of the Gentiles. Partners signify later pastors and teachers; Christ still fills the net and calls those in the world's depths.	Later ministers cooperate in an apostolic work whose efficacy and content remain Christ's.
St. Ambrose	<i>Exposition of Luke</i> IV.68–72	Christ chooses Peter's boat and commands <i>Duc in altum</i> . Ambrose's depth includes the profound confession of the Son's divine generation; nets signify apostolic discourse bringing people from depths to light alive.	Launching into the deep is not merely motivational boldness. Received doctrine governs mission.
St. Ambrose	IV.76–79	Empty presumption becomes fruitful humility; the two boats can signify peoples or Churches; Peter's fear and confession are answered by divine gift and vocation.	Ambrose's symbolic identifications are exegesis of the scene, not Luke's literal description of later institutions.

St. Cyril — sign as pledge, mission as continuing gift

At Luke 5:2–8 Cyril places word and work together. The miracle gives spectators a pledge of Christ's power and gives the apostles a visible type of future labor among the nations. Their night was truly empty; their evangelical labor will not be fruitless because Christ, not the net, supplies the catch.

St. Ambrose — depth is doctrinal before it is strategic

In IV.71 Ambrose turns *Duc in altum* toward the depth of the mystery of the Son. In IV.72 the apostolic nets bring persons from the obscurity of the depths into spiritual light without destroying them. Missionary action is therefore downstream from Christological confession, not a substitute for it.

The narrative's seven movements

1. Christ teaches before he commands the mission.
2. The command enters the precise place where expertise has met its limit.
3. Simon reports the whole failure without disguising it.
4. *In verbo autem tuo* places obedience on Christ's word before results appear.
5. Abundance exceeds private capacity and summons partners.
6. Gift reveals the giver's holiness and brings Peter to confession.

7. Christ answers fear with vocation; the catch culminates in following him.

Luke's Catch and John's Shore

Augustine reads Luke 5 canonically by setting it beside John 21. He does not erase either narrative's historical sense. Their differences become a two-panel ecclesiology: the Church in the present age and the Church after resurrection.

Feature	Luke 5	John 21	Augustine's reading
Place in the Gospel	Before the Passion and Resurrection	In a Resurrection appearance	The temporal settings permit present and final conditions to be contrasted.
Catch	An immense, unspecified multitude fills two boats	A definite number, 153, is drawn to the risen Lord	The present Church gathers numbers not yet finally disclosed; the kingdom has a completed number known to God.
Nets	They strain and tear	The net is explicitly not torn	Augustine associates present rupture with schism and the final net with communion no longer breakable.
Fish	No right-side selection or sorting is narrated	The cast is on the right; the fish are brought to shore	Augustine reads Luke's catch as good and bad together, John's as the good manifested at the end.
Boats and shore	Two burdened boats nearly sink	The risen Christ stands on land and receives the catch	The two boats can signify Jews and Gentiles joined in Christ; the shore signifies resurrection's stability.

St. Augustine — direct canonical comparison

Sermon 248, 1–3, states the controlling distinction: the two catches signify the Church as it is now and as it will be in the resurrection. *Tractate 122 on John*, 7, develops the same contrast from the nets, sides, number, and shore. This is Augustine's theological reading of two Gospel narratives, not a claim that Luke's author explicitly narrates the final sorting in chapter 5.

A control on claims of success and purity

The first catch is truly Christ's gift, yet it strains structures and contains persons whose final condition is not visible. Abundance cannot certify every fisher, every fish, or every institutional result. Nor do strain and rupture prove that Christ's word failed. The present Church receives a real catch while awaiting the unbroken communion of the final shore.

Peter's Conversion Within His Vocation

Peter does not move from competence to promotion. He moves from exhausted competence, through obedience and astonishment, into confession and a call whose efficacy remains Christ's.

Peter's word or act	Patristic precision	Moral consequence
We labored all night and took nothing	Ambrose contrasts fruitless presumption with the humility that submits to Christ; Cyril lets failure make the miracle's source unmistakable.	Honest accounting of failure need not become despair or self-exoneration.
At your word I will let down the net	Obedience is attached to the speaker's authority, not confidence in unchanged circumstances.	Faith acts before it can use success as evidence.
Depart from me, for I am sinful	Cyril treats Peter's fear as reverence before purity; Ambrose sees confession as fitting before gift.	Fruit should deepen repentance. Results do not function as a certificate of holiness.
Fear not	Christ neither denies Peter's sin nor accepts separation as its necessary end.	Grace can preserve truth about guilt while refusing the conclusion of hopeless distance.
From now on you will catch men	Vocation is promise before it is possession; the apostles are themselves caught and then made fishers.	The called person follows Christ and bears a received ministry rather than owning the catch.

The Offertory: Eyes Kept Awake

Psalm 12:4–5

Illumina oculos meos, ne unquam obdormiam in morte: nequando dicat inimicus meus: Praevalui adversus eum.
 Enlighten my eyes, lest I ever sleep in death; lest at any time my enemy say: I have prevailed against him.

St. Augustine — direct exegesis of the offered verse

In *Exposition on Psalm 12* (the page headed Psalm 13 in modern numbering), 3–6, Augustine identifies the enemy as the devil or carnal habit. The eyes are the eyes of the heart, endangered by the pleasurable eclipse of sin. Remaining unmoved in faith is itself attributed to God's mercy rather than to pride. This is direct same-psalm exegesis; applying it to the verse's Offertory placement is editorial liturgical synthesis.

Psalm movement	Interior danger	Gift requested	Relation to the Gospel
God's face seems turned away	Discouragement interprets delay as abandonment	Renewed regard and hearing	The empty night is reported without making it the last word.
The enemy is exalted	Devil or entrenched carnal habit claims mastery	Deliverance from domination	Peter's expertise is not the only interior authority that may need contradiction.
Eyes risk sleep in death	Sin darkens the heart by a pleasurable eclipse	Illumination	The Introit's God who is light is asked to act within perception.
Troublers await collapse	The will may be moved away from steadfast faith	Stability in mercy	The catch's strain does not have to become apostasy or self-reliance.
The heart exults in salvation	Pride is displaced by thanksgiving	Joy in Christ	Peter leaves the catch and follows the giver.

What is offered before the Secret

The Church does not first offer a record of successful labor. She offers a plea for sight. Only an illumined heart can distinguish Christ's command from self-will, abundance from self-vindication, and merciful interior movement from brute compulsion.

The Secret: Oblations Received, Rebellious Wills Drawn

The complete prayer

Oblationibus nostris, quaesumus, Domine, placare susceptis: et ad te nostras etiam rebelles compelle propitius voluntates. Per Dominum.

Our oblations having been received, we beseech thee, O Lord, be appeased; and mercifully compel even our rebellious wills toward thee.

Latin hinge	Grammatical force	Theological pressure
<i>Oblationibus nostris . . . susceptis</i>	An ablative absolute: our oblations having been received	Acceptance remains God's act and the prayer's premise; possession does not force the giver's favor.
<i>placare</i>	A passive imperative: be appeased or favorably disposed	Sacrifice is ordered toward reconciliation, not technique or display.
<i>et ad te</i>	A second petition joined by <i>et</i> , with God as its personal end	Conversion is not merely improved performance; the will is drawn toward God himself.
<i>nostras etiam rebelles voluntates</i>	<i>voluntates</i> is the object of <i>compelle</i> ; <i>etiam rebelles</i> names the wills even as resistant	Prayer neither hides resistance nor treats it as sovereign and immovable.
<i>compelle propitius</i>	The imperative asks efficacious action; <i>propitius</i> governs its mode as gracious and favorable	Mercy and efficacy must be held together. The text does not ask God to injure, bypass, or annihilate the will.

A necessary syntactic boundary

The Latin contains two coordinated petitions: receive the oblations and be appeased; mercifully compel rebellious wills toward God. It does *not* grammatically identify the wills as the oblations. Their relation within one prayer is liturgically significant, but calling the will an interior offering is an editorial theological inference, not a translation.

St. Augustine — the divided will is still one person

Confessions VIII.5 and 8–12 narrates a will divided by entrenched habit: the mind commands itself and meets resistance because neither opposing act of willing is whole. Augustine rejects the Manichaean inference that two wills prove two alien substances. Grace does not erase the agent in Augustine's conversion; it frees and unifies the person whose disordered willing could not heal itself.

St. Augustine — God acts within willing

On Grace and Free Will 41–43 argues from Scripture that human acts are voluntary while God has lordship even within the movement of hearts. Chapter 43 distinguishes merciful inclination toward good from righteous judgment upon prior evil and insists that grace is gratuitous. This is doctrinal illumination of *compelle propitius*, not evidence that Augustine wrote or directly expounded the Secret.

St. John Chrysostom — divine working does not make the person inert

Homily 8 on Philippians, on 2:12–13, joins the command to work out salvation to God working both willing and action. Chrysostom treats divine action as confidence against despair and still calls for a resolute mind, obedience, and practiced good. His idiom is not identical to Augustine's, but both rule out a will sufficient without grace and a grace that renders moral action unreal.

How the Gospel controls the prayer

Christ's command at the lake is not physical violence against Simon. It addresses, elicits, and carries obedient action: Simon objects truthfully, consents at Christ's word, acts, confesses, and follows. The narrative does not define the technical theology of *compelle*; it gives this Mass a concrete pattern in which efficacious divine authority and real human response are not competitors.

From Groaning Body to Sacramental Protection

The Communion names God as firm ground, refuge, liberator, and helper. The Postcommunion asks that the mysteries already received purify and protect. The movement answers every scale opened earlier: a corruptible body is nourished toward resurrection, a burdened Church is held by a strength not its own, and a resistant will remains under medicinal grace.

St. Irenaeus — Eucharist and the body's future

Against Heresies V.2.2–3 argues that created bread and wine become Christ's Eucharistic body and blood and nourish our flesh; therefore the flesh is capable of God's gift and will rise in incorruption. Irenaeus supplies a sacramental bridge from Romans' redemption of the body to Communion. He is not commenting on this Sunday's antiphon or Postcommunion.

Liturgical phase	Received action	Patristic control
Introit + Collect	Divine light gives courage, and providence orders the world's course and the Church's devotion.	Creation is good and governed; peace is not withdrawal from creaturely history.
Epistle + Gradual + Alleluia	Travail is placed under hope; sin is confessed; the equitable Judge is refuge for the poor.	Chrysostom and Irenaeus keep glory bodily, gratuitous, and future without making firstfruits unreal.
Gospel	Christ teaches, commands, fills, receives confession, and calls.	Cyril keeps efficacy Christ's; Ambrose keeps depth doctrinal; Augustine keeps the present catch from claiming final purity.
Offertory + Secret	Eyes ask illumination; oblations ask acceptance; rebellious wills ask merciful direction toward God.	Augustine and Chrysostom preserve both interior divine action and responsible willing.
Communion + Postcommunion	God is received as refuge; received mysteries purify and guard.	Irenaeus joins Eucharistic nourishment to the same body's incorruptible future.

Guardrails for the whole reading

- Hope does not minimize travail: birth imagery gives suffering an end without calling suffering good in itself.
- Bodily redemption is not escape from matter: the mortal body is raised and creation is liberated from corruption.
- Obedience is not denial of evidence: Simon truthfully reports failure before acting at Christ's word.
- Abundance is not proof of sanctity: the gift brings Peter to confession, and the present catch remains mixed.
- Ecclesial strain is not divine failure: Augustine can read torn nets as present schism while still naming the catch Christ's.

- *Compelle* is not a warrant for human coercion: the prayer addresses God and qualifies his action as *propitiis*.
- Grace is not passivity: God works within willing and action, healing resistance into real obedience.
- Sacramental reception is not the end of conversion: the Church still asks to be purified and protected by what she has received.

A compact patristic listening sequence

1. At the Introit and Collect, place conflict, creation, and ecclesial devotion beneath God's light and ordering.
2. In Romans, hear Chrysostom's travail moving toward birth and Irenaeus's insistence that this mortal body is raised.
3. At the Gradual and Alleluia, confess sin before measuring fruit; the enthroned Judge is also refuge for the poor.
4. In the Gospel, follow the order: doctrine, command, truthful failure, obedience, gift, confession, reassurance, vocation.
5. With Cyril, locate efficacy in Christ; with Ambrose, enter the depth of received doctrine; with Augustine, distinguish the present catch from the final shore.
6. At the Offertory, ask for the heart's eyes to be kept awake against sin's eclipse.
7. At the Secret, hear both petitions and their grammar; offer without pretending that the resistant will heal itself.
8. At Communion and after it, receive God as refuge and ask the mysteries to purify, guard, and prepare the body for incorruption.

Primary References

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